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Ray Drummond

Ray Drummond was born on November 23, 1946 in Brookline, Massachusetts. As a bassist, he has performed and recorded with an impressive list of leading jazz artists and has led his own groups since the 1970s. While maintaining an active performing schedule, he currently directs much of his energies toward composing and teaching.

Ray was interviewed in Toronto, Canada on January 9, 2003 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in Toronto for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. It's a real pleasure to have Ray Drummond with me here, composer and bassist, band leader, and keeper of a neat website.

RD: Thank you. I wasn't expecting that. I thought you'd say professor next. Budding professor.

MR: Budding professor. Oh yeah, you just got an appointment?

RD: Yes.

MR: Where is that?

RD: California State University Monterey Bay, which is the former Fort Ord. So the federal government gave it to the State of California who in turn gave it to the California State University system. So up until this past semester we were the newest of the California State University campuses. There's a new one now that has actually started this past September so we're not the newest one, but we're one of the smaller ones, we only have 3200 students and we're eight years old.

MR: How are you going to do that?

RD: Well I'm not moving back to Monterey Bay anytime soon except maybe to get a place three or four years downstream. My family has lived in the Monterey Peninsula for the last forty years. So my pop passed away a couple of years ago and so my mom's been living there by herself. And so it's wonderful to see her prodigal son come back home, back there to hang out with her for various periods of time. Because it's a full time appointment on the tenure track and all that.

MR: Okay. So you'll be doing some commuting from coast to coast?

RD: Yes. I have been commuting. As the old vaudeville joke goes, and my arms are tired. Back and forth. I think it's seven times since August, back and forth, seven or eight times. So it'll probably continue maybe five times or so during the next semester. And then of course I'm free from the middle of May until the end of August. So I've been

Thielmans, all during this time, from being there, and have some other projects that I'm involved in. One is a French project that takes me over there a couple of times a year minimum. And I would really like to get my own show back on the road but that's had to take a back burner by necessity because there's so much else going on.

MR: Yeah. Is it hard to be a band leader?

RD: Well there are two parts to that answer. One yes, these days it's more difficult to get gigs primarily because most people are represented. So unless you are represented, it's not that you're at a disadvantage it's just that people who are the presenters are more used to now working with people, managers, agents, than musicians. I mean more and more now the business has become more institutionalized and so it's not that the presenters don't want to but the presenters have gotten used to working primarily with quote other professional people rather than the musicians themselves. I think they feel more comfortable, you know they have their own little cliques and all that sort of stuff you know. But that's the first part of the answer. The second part is one that's instrument specific. Bass players have not really been given much chance — they don't get the same chances at becoming band leaders that trumpet players, saxophone players, drummers sometimes seem able to get what we call more play at becoming a leader. More opportunities to become a leader. Piano players are accepted as leaders immediately. That sort of thing. But it's kind of — bass — we have always been in the background creating the heartbeats for groups that we perform with and so the bass player that steps out and says I'm the leader. Okay there's another component to that though, and it has to do with the instrument itself. Because people don't really, in one sense they don't listen to the bass as a melodic instrument in the same way that a piano or trumpet or saxophone or trombone or baritone saxophone even — talk about instruments that are closer to the bass in terms of pitch. So what has happened is that we now seem to have to fight to become band leaders. Charles Mingus is a perfect example of someone who obviously was a band leader and yet he had to struggle and fight to be known. People still think of him primarily as a composer and a composer who with his band played primarily his compositions. Yet on the other hand you have the fact that he was obviously a leader. He obviously wanted to train other musicians, one. Because that's in my opinion one of the functions of a leader is to actually serve as a training ground, the kinds of bands that leaders have, ones where you actually have musicians in your groups who are going to become leaders themselves go on to do whatever it is that they're supposed to be doing. Although there are some exceptions to that. And of course like Duke Ellington for instance was not someone to particularly develop talent, but he could have, but because he was writing for those musicians individually many of them decided — look at Johnny

because of the fact that Duke always would write these wonderful, wonderful venues for him, these wonderful pieces of music, and sure he could play it with his own group but it just didn't have the same kind of impact for him I think. I think he just got a great feeling out of playing Duke's music too. And so it's like Duke made sure that you had enough money to survive so it's kind of like why bite the hand that feeds me, that sort of thing, and that also nurtures you.

MR: Do you feel that some young jazz musicians become leaders too soon?

RD: Oh you get me started on this. Yes obviously. I mean Clifford Brown was a leader, he died what when he was 25, 26 years old when he died, but he was really a leader. He was a very responsible young man. To this day LaRue, his widow, Clifford was the kind of guy, they were buying a home when he died, and he had homeowner's insurance, life insurance, that's the kind of responsibility he had. I mean he understood if he did die then the house would be paid for, and that's what happened. So I mean he had that kind of foresight and that sense of responsibility. And I venture to say there are very few of these young musicians — I'm not going to call any names at this point because it's not about a pissing contest or who's good and who's bad, but it's just that it's been very unfortunate that in the top down theory that seems to be prevailing through the higher echelons of not just the entertainment business but the jazz business, they seem to think that they need to not rely on an apprentice system, apprenticeship system, that actually served jazz quite well in the development of individual voices one, and the development of individual leaders two. And so when you come and you just pluck people out of line, take them out of line and put them in the wrong place in the line, you're really messing with a fundamental strength that this music, and the resiliency that this music has always showed. Because that's one of the things — if you start messing with the evolutionary scheme then don't be surprised if you have some very serious, strange looking hybrids and genetically defective examples in your bloodline now. Because I mean jazz has never been tinkered with in the way that it has been in the last twenty years.

MR: Is this whole thing here with the jazz convention and jazz education, is that in any way messing with the evolution?

RD: No. You're talking about the convention itself?

MR: I'm talking about the concept I guess of — gosh I guess teaching jazz in a college.

RD: No, no. None of that. No, no. There are two issues with this convention. I'm not sure — first of all you have to understand I'm a political sociologist. That's my degree. That's what my undergraduate degree was really in. And so I see two specific missions that aren't necessarily compatible that are not exclusive and they don't conflict with one another but they have parts of each other that do conflict. Okay on the one hand this

convention has now taken on an additional responsibility, especially now since the *Jazz Times* convention folded or actually more accurately has folded a small portion of itself into this particular convention. So you've got really a pull between the commercial forces of the media, of the entertainment industry, meaning the record companies and other media companies that are interested in the commercial media. You've got them pulling at the educational because they're trying to get them to feed them and yet there is a certain kind of dynamic that exists in jazz education because as you know there has always been kind of a hidden war — it's not war but a hidden conflict between the musicians, professional musicians, and the educators which is really unfortunate. It's really ridiculous. Because everybody's trying to do the exact same thing, which is to make the pie bigger for the jazz community. I mean the musicians not only are they looking for more venues but they're looking for audience. The universities have the perfect opportunity to not only have musicians in music programs and whatnot but to actually be a place where future audiences can actually learn something about jazz, classical music, folk music, world music, whatever. And then as they go out to work, become lawyers, doctors, dentists, police officers, whatever, diplomats, the point is that they have been exposed to other things and they begin to make quote informed choices you know. So to me it's obvious that the mission for both camps is exactly the same. But somewhere along the line you've got some people who actually say oh you're an educator, oh. You're not as good as a professional. Or a professional saying well you're an educator so you don't think I'm as good as you. It's like wait a minute guys. It's very specious as far as I'm concerned, that part of it. So you have that happening, that's traditional, that's been part of this organization, that's part of the baggage that this organization has always carried with it, and then now you've also grafted this other media hype business that has got more muscle and more money in one sense because it's more dynamic. So at least — and it's also the one that's tied in to youthful notions of what it means to be quote successful unquote. Because success, we know, really doesn't have much to do — it has somewhat to do with commercial success — but that's not what we really as educators or as professionals, jazz lovers, are looking for. It's not so much most musicians I don't think come into jazz music because I'm going to make a killing, I'm going to be the next Rockefeller, I'm going to be the next thing, I'm going to be the next Beatles. I mean you know it's not on that level. It's usually I have this passion for this music that I've always loved, it's nurtured me, it's gotten me through hard times and more importantly it's something that I just feel compelled to actually be in this community and to try to one acquire and develop and deepen this voice that I think I hear or feel or however it appears to you. And I think that this is the mission of educators as well. I think people that really

time in 25 years I'm back now in an institutional setting as a faculty member and I'm really enjoying it again. But then I knew I would because I like teaching. But I took myself off the market for 25 years because I wanted to be fully a professional musician. I didn't want — it wasn't that it was a problem being an educator it's just that I wanted to see what it was going to be like for me to be out there earning my own living without an institution behind me, without any of the — I mean it's not a safety net, it's just a different way of being employed. It's a different relationship. You're still working for yourself but you have another kind of relationship that you have to nurture. And the political aspects of being in the educational establishment, I mean that's a whole other thing. I mean it's similar to what you have to do and the political aspects of your career as a professional musician. But it's a different — I mean it's a different institutional setting.

MR: Do you think you personally went — I'm not sure how to phrase this — went as far as you could in the performing world? I mean you had obvious — you've played with—

RD: A gaggle of people.

MR: A gaggle. Thank you. Of motley characters, which is something you said to me over the phone I guess. I wouldn't call them that.

RD: Desperados.

MR: Desperados.

RD: Yes. Desperados, everybody.

MR: And you've had some recordings under your own name and you've led your own groups.

RD: Have I gone as far as I could?

MR: Yeah.

RD: No.

MR: Okay.

RD: No. I haven't really even scratched the surface yet in terms of what — I mean I have a whole bunch of things on my plate with respect to being a performing artist. Productions, talking about recordings primarily, that I would like to continue to do, that I would like to do over the next few years. Right now I don't know, I woke up one day and decided that it's time for me to give back in a way that I haven't given back. I mean I enjoy teaching but I don't enjoy cranking out musicians. That I've never really enjoyed. And the reason for that is I like to be with young musicians, student musicians, I like to get them on track so that they can discover what they need to discover for themselves. Because ultimately what I think the thing that I see in jazz education today is that it's not a question of if anybody's right or wrong, but it seems to me that what we need to do is to empower the students for them to be able to then say okay, now I've been exposed to a basic kind of

your own personality. Get your own sound. It's just not been a value that we've actually elevated to the same status as get your articulation together, get your knowledge of jazz history together, get your knowledge of your instrument together, get the kind of fundamental music business training that you need so that when you do come out with a degree that you're going to have at least some of the tools necessary to actually be a professional. That's what we've been doing, which is great. But for these kids to really become not just successful jazz musicians but to be — what's the word, I can't think — it's not appropriate but to be — not well rounded, there's a word I'm trying to find here — but in order to be — it's not successful, that's not the word I'm trying to come up with.

MR: Relevant?

RD: Relevant is closer. To be not just relevant but in order for it to be real for each one of these musicians, they really have to — see when I was coming up, and most generations before me, one of the main things we used to listen are the older guys. One of the things they used to tell us is look kid, if you don't do anything with your music or your instrument, get your own sound. Get your own ability to have a signature sound. Harry Carney — his own sound. Johnny Hodges — his own sound. Duke Ellington — his own sound. Bill Evans — his own sound. You hit a couple of notes — ooh, that's Bill Evans. Ooh, that's Hank Jones. That's Paul Chambers. And you know the point is that that was a really serious value and even if — I can remember when I was growing up, this is like fifties, into the sixties, you're playing some of these smaller big bands, for some jobs, Moose Lodge, the Elks, bar mitzvahs, whatever it might be, a band that was made up of half the guys were a couple of accountants and a couple of doctors, a couple of lawyers, some high school kids, university kids, a couple of ringers, the professional guys that worked around. But this was a band that worked. In Monterey Peninsula there was a band called the Delmonte Express that used to be like that and I used to like to go and play bass with them sometimes. But when I first started playing with them I used to play French horn with them every now and then when they had some charts that needed some French horn I'd go play with them. But the point was there would always be one or two guys in the band, like a third alto player or something who would stand up, and he wouldn't — he'd play a solo but the solo would be written out and this guy's probably a doctor or something you know, but it's written out and he played a solo, he'd play the same exact stuff every time we played the chart. But it didn't matter because he stood up and took the solo that was written out. But his sound was so wonderful. That's why we had him. That's why you have this guy. Because he had this wonderful sound that he had taken the time to develop. He's not Coltrane, he's not ever going to become a

And he learned how to actually develop, get a voice, and put it out there. And that kind of voice is, it's possible for anybody to have that voice. Anyone who is passionate about the music, whether they become a professional musician or not, and that really is instructive as to how I think the next level of jazz education needs to be — shall we say — augmented. We just need to find a way to bring personal voice up to the same level as all the other values that we're trying to instill in the students. Because in my opinion as a professional musician is I'm working with the product of the jazz education system for the last 25 or 30 years, that's the one thing that I'm really disappointed about. Saxophone players — it doesn't matter. We're not talking about instrument specific here. Because I mean I rant on my website about bass players, how they go — it's like they're going into a supermarket and going to a white can, and the can is marked "generic bass sound" and so they take the can home and open it up and that's them because young guys playing with microphones — and you say I'm only going to play with the microphone, no pick-ups, no amps. So then you say okay, great, do that. So you listen to recordings, you say who is that? You can't differentiate because they're all — the sound that they get on the instruments are exactly the same. And then I'll listen to Rufus Reid, Ron Carter, Buster Williams and Cecil McBee, George Mraz, you know John Patitucci, all these different guys will actually, they might play through a pick-up on a record, they might play on a stage through an amp with their own pick-up, their own bass, all the set-up, two notes, that's Ron Carter.

MR: You can still tell.

RD: Of course. Even with the so-called electronic — the personality is right there.

MR: Where does that come from? How do you teach that?

RD: That comes from elevating the idea, the concept of get your own voice, regardless of what you're going to do with it. Because they used to say look, anybody can practice, anybody can become somewhat proficient on an instrument, I mean if you have any kind of musical talent. It's not a question of whether or not you really use this entire amount of information that you've not gotten from practicing in order to run your scales and run all this fancy stuff around. I mean I have to say somebody that's almost a perfect example of somebody who has his own sound and obviously is a wonderful saxophone player but it ain't telling us nothing is Kenny G as a good example. The boy is obviously a good saxophone player. There's no question. But he has no knowledge of jazz history. The boy, I mean unless this is one of those take a page from the bebop book so I'll tell people anything and they'll think I'm crazy or weird or out of it or whatever. Because some of the things he said, especially with respect to jazz history and with respect to the older jazzmen, I'm talking the jazz tradition, are just ludicrous. Absolutely ludicrous. And he

sound that he obviously has taken time on. I heard him play tenor one time on a record and it was very interesting because it's like he's using the same format, the same template and the same sound actually in a tenor. I mean it just sounds like Kenny G playing tenor.

MR: Yeah I noticed something on your website. You said, "Where the jazz in smooth jazz?"

RD: Yeah, well, don't get me started on that because the smooth jazz — see jazz is a big tent. And there's nothing wrong with jazz being a big tent. I don't have a problem with that. The problem I have is when the non-jazz people try to take jazz — not only the term but try to usurp the tradition to make the tradition appear as if it actually sprung from this little popcorn stuff that they're into. That has nothing to do with art, it just has to do with entertainment, it has also to do with a commercial kind of marketing approach, in other words a post-twentieth century kind of approach to entertainment as opposed to art. And so then when people in education are trying to study this, unless you're very clear-minded about it and you design your programs in a clear-minded way, it's very easy for people including musicians to be confused as to what is entertainment, what is art, what are the histories of these various things, the pulls that are involved. I was in the elevator today, this morning. It was really funny. There were some young musicians, high school or maybe younger university students, you know like freshmen or sophomores. And one guy was saying to the other guy, yeah I was just standing in the elevator, and the guy says, "Oh man, that Kenny G, that's one of the saddest musicians. Boy the guy can play saxophone, he really can, but my parents have the Christmas album, you know, they played that when I was home, man that is horrible." The kid says, "Really?" "Oh it's terrible, you wouldn't believe how it sucks." I said now this is young guys. Nobody's putting anything down their gullets or anything. And this guy is telling his friend, like man this stuff sucks man, what is this? And he didn't even say Bird or Trane or anything, he just said, "Man this is horrible music, just terrible." And of course on the other hand it's a white cat too. A white kid. And on the other hand I'll show you black folks that — I'll take you to some places and introduce you to some people, say, "Tell me, how do you feel about Kenny G?" And they'll say, "Oh Kenny G is so wonderful, oh his music is so stirring to me." [whistles]. But he does have a sound. He does have a sound.

MR: He's got some formula that apparently appeals to some people.

RD: That he took from Grover Washington of course. I mean Grover is the one that really is the inspiration for Kenny G. If he would just say that, that would make me, then I would get off my high horse. I mean really say well the boy, no matter what he's doing at least he's honest about where he's stealing it from. I mean Duke Ellington would tell you in a minute, "Yeah I stole that from Tchaikovsky, and I took that from Fats Waller and I took this— and I just heard this somewhere, I probably stole it from somewhere but I don't

know where he got it from." But you know, as Duke used to say, good composers borrow, the best composers steal. The way it is.

MR: Well you moved around a lot as a —

RD: Military, Army brat.

MR: Yeah. Did that have any effect on your choice of career?

RD: I don't think so. No. Because the fact that my father was a musician in World War II initially, he went into the Army as a musician, he was a saxophone player, a saxophone and clarinet player. And then he decided I guess a couple of years into the military, they didn't call him up — I mean he was in the Army, but in the military bands. And he had an opportunity to become a Tuskegee Airman. They were going around looking for pilots, people that were interested in flying. And he signed up for that and became a Tuskegee Airman and was a bomber pilot but didn't serve in Japan. In fact they were getting ready to ship out I guess when World War II ended and so he never did get a chance to see any action there. Then he became a Reserve person and went into the Army. The DOD was created, Defense Department was created in '47 so anybody that was Reserve was asked, okay now you're a pilot, do you want to go into the Air Force or do you want to stay in the Army into Army Aviation? So he decided to stay in Army Aviation. And then he was called back up to Active Duty in Korea, when the Korean War broke out. And so we wound up going to Germany actually, in 1951. From that point on then we started moving around all over the place. From one Army post to another. So 14 schools in 12 years. I graduated from the same school I started in, which was in Nuremberg Germany.

MR: I'll be darned, you did a circle?

RD: I did a whole circle through 13 other schools. I started in the back, Nuremberg Elementary School, first grade, and then I graduated in the front twelve years later from Nuremberg Senior High School. So I got the diploma to prove it. Class of 1964, which also included Diane Wiest. She was Colonel Wiest's daughter. I have my yearbook Nuremberg High School yearbook. I still have it in my house. And on this page I'm sitting there, a full size picture of the outstanding senior in music. Ray Drummond with his French horn and my little now-skinny tie from 1964; and here's this other page next to it, you open it up like that and here is this full sized picture of a girl, a teenager who is all made up for "Pygmalion" she was the main character in "Pygmalion." I forget if she's supposed to be a gypsy or hobo or something like that, anyway she's all made up in character. And that's Diane Wiest. Nuremberg High School class of '64. It was really amazing. I've to call her, because she lives in New York as well. I haven't seen her since graduation.

RD: Yeah. But I can get in touch with her because we both belong to the—

MR: You played brass instruments and then did someone like put you to the bass for some reason?

RD: Yes. Yes. In California my junior high school teacher, who had pushed me from the trumpet to the French horn, needed some bass players for the school orchestra for the summer school, as I was going from junior high school to Monterey High School. But we were rehearsing in the high school. So he came to me and he said, "I need bass players, are you interested?" And I said — I thought about it — but he knew if I said yes then I'd take the bass home, practice it well enough to get past the concert, because I was always diligent about that sort of thing. So finally I said, "Yeah okay" I'd do it. Mr. Buffo, Mel Buffo, who is still, thank goodness, alive and well in the Monterey Peninsula in California.

MR: And you got a degree in sociology?

RD: Well political science actually.

MR: Political science. Decided not to pursue a career in that at that time?

RD: No actually I first took a job for two years as a personnel interviewer, management trainee for Allstate Insurance Company. I worked in two regional offices actually, and I was also like the Affirmative Action officer for the two regions. And I was also a personnel interviewer. So I was a personnel grunt for them and in the management rotational program, which was very interesting, and you know, a Chicago based company. Northbrook, Illinois. Sears & Roebuck, at least at that time they were definitely all totally owned by Sears. I don't know where they are now, I mean in terms of being owned. But it was very interesting. It was my first job out of college and I did it for two years and then I decided that I wanted to take advantage of an opportunity of — I was living in downtown Palo Alto, California, and my wife was working at Stanford — my first wife was working at Stanford in the sociology department. Actually she was the secretary to the head of the sociology department. And so I found out about an opportunity of a fellowship for the Stanford Business School and so I applied and, you know you take your GREs and all that sort of stuff. So anyway, I won a fellowship, the Council on Graduate Management Education for two years of study, the two year program, the MBA program at Stanford. And so I went for one year. They were paying everything — tuition, food stipend, rent, books, everything. I mean all I had to do was go to school for two years. And I was very unhappy with my colleagues. The time was 1970 so we had a lot of Vietnam Navy pilots especially coming back. And they were coming into the classes. There were a lot of them too. And my father was a Vietnam veteran also. What had happened with pop is in aviation he started with the fixed wing aircraft and

into helicopters. So he became a commander. Because he was a Colonel when he retired. But pop was a chopper commander so when he was transferred at the end of my freshman year, the summer that I went back to Germany between my freshman and sophomore years, he got orders to Vietnam and so he was the first group of the big buildup of choppers that they started to ship over to Vietnam for the war. So we picked up the summer of '65 and went back to the Peninsula. Of course I was going to school, I had to finish my freshman year already in Claremont and so I was just coming back to California anyhow. But now the whole family went back and then pop went on to Vietnam. But he wound up there — he was there for about 15 months I guess and got a Purple Heart and all that sort of stuff. But he was really gung ho trying to get me to go, because I was in ROTC and all that sort of stuff. But I couldn't see going. And there were a lot of other circumstances. I wound up not going. But the point was that in B school, here I've got these pilots coming back and they're all like, "Oh yeah we're really — we're Vietnam veterans" and most of these guys were in carriers, took off every day. By that time, 1970, there was hardly any SAMS — you know surface-to-air missiles coming up at 'em. And there were no MIGS anymore. They shot all the North Vietnamese MIGS down. I mean the early sixties, when my father was there, '65, '66, '67, that's when those guys got creamed. That's when McCain wound up getting shot down and all these guys were shot down and POWs and all. But after, from 1969 on, there's no resistance in the skies. Americans did whatever they wanted to do. So anyway, to make a long story short, these guys are coming back all cocky and all this kind of — I said wait a minute. If I get this MBA and go off in that direction I'm going wind up — these are my significant others, this is my good old boy network. I've got to call up that — can I say asshole — I'm going to have to call that asshole and say okay look, I've got a deal here with my company and blah blah blah, or I'm going to sit on a board of directors across from them and be saying oh I think we need to do this. Man, you were an asshole at Stanford and you're still an asshole. Why do I have to listen to this bullshit. This is not right for what we need to do with this board of directors up here. So I said to myself well if that's the way I feel I need to think about what I really want to do with my life. And of course I had been playing all the time, playing gigs and bar mitzvahs and weddings and big bands and even doing jazz gigs. I mean I was up playing with different jazz musicians both locally and occasionally do something with somebody that's more known. I was even playing for instance Monday nights with Chet Baker. You know Chet Baker got out of prison and his mother was living up in Milpitas, just north of San Jose. And I used to go over to Chet's mother's house and we would rehearse. We had this Monday night gig in a pizza parlor in San Jose. And later Chet moved up to San Francisco and so he had me working. I only

San Francisco and I only lasted there for about two or three weeks because by that time I was already a musician up there and it was so ridiculous because Chet was really trying to just score, trying to get some stuff together. So sometimes we wouldn't even get paid. So I mean it was just some silly stuff. So I said later for this. But in San Jose, earlier, I did things like that. So I said to myself you know that's really something that I really enjoy doing is playing the music. And of course I'd been learning tunes and writing things, and I'd learned how to play piano and had this record collection that kept getting bigger and bigger and bigger, because I'd been collecting records since I was about nine, ten years old and just enjoying the music. Like I told everybody in the clinic, I was a listener long before I was a performer. And I've chosen never to lose my listening chops. Never.

MR: Tell me about working with Bobby Hutcherson.

RD: What do you want to know?

MR: Well is it different playing behind—

RD: The texture. The texture is different. Saxophone player, that's a reed. When you have a bar that's vibrating that's different. If the guy out in front is like Ron Carter playing his piccolo bass that's a different timbre. I've done those. I've played with Ron as the bass player and it's fun. I enjoyed it. But it's different. Piano trio or piano-led band is different. Trombone-led, like if you work with Steve Turre for instance, the timbre is different. You do make an adjustment but I'm sure the adjustment is a very subtle one. In terms of where you place time or stuff like that, there's no change from that. But there are color changes, yes. I would definitely say that there's some kind of a difference. And even with individual instruments. If I were to take the gigs I play with Bobby Hutcherson, the gigs I played with Milt Jackson, the gigs I played with Steve Nelson, they all have such individual personalities, although they're all in that, you know it's like Bags evolved into Bobby Hutcherson evolved into Steve Nelson. So even though there's that common thread they're from the same trunk — from the same branch of the trunk. Their individual styles are so — the color of their music — I was going to say the color of their notes, but it's really the color of their music is so different that you play — there are some very, very subtle changes that you make in your music. What they are I can't tell you.

MR: Yeah, it's hard.

RD: But I don't have the same template with everybody that I play with. I don't. I don't use the same — I use the same approach in terms of I'm Ray Drummond who feels this way and who hears this way and I do that consistently. But the name of that game, I mean the range of that game is totally dependent on the music itself, the selections, the kind of

jazz alone, I won't even get into the things I like to listen to but I don't want to play, but jazz — and I've got some funny stories with respect to how in one sense it's been kind of a labor to expand my — not just understanding — but my appreciation of musics that — I'll give you examples.

MR: Yeah please.

RD: For instance, the first time I heard — I was a senior in high school in Germany and I went down to the PX and bought this record Bill Evans "Sunday Live at the Village Vanguard." I brought that back home, Scott LaFaro, Paul Motian. Put it on, now Bill Evans for me was this guy who used to play with Miles back in the late fifties and he's on a couple of Miles' records and so and I remember he also used to play with people like Jimmy Giuffre, Tony Scott, there were some — I remember that. But I never had any of those records. I just remember hearing a couple of things and kind of enjoying it and sort of west coastish but no not really, but — because I never listened to anything but his Bud Powell roots which is where Bill Evans really came out of anyway. But so I buy this record, put it on and start playing. I guess the first tune is "Gloria's Step" and then it goes on from there, various tunes and whatever is on the record. But "Alice in Wonderland" and all sorts of other things. And I'm saying to myself what's wrong — because I'm thinking Wynton Kelly and Paul Chambers, Jimmy Cobb or Philly Joe and Wynton Kelly and Paul Chambers and Percy Heath playing with Mickey Roker, all this king of thing, Ray Brown with Kenny Clarke and John Lewis and Milt Jackson and stuff. And here's these guys playing [scats] and they get into musical conversation. Man these guys don't swing. What's wrong with these guys. This is some sad — boy to pay two dollars and thirty-five cents for this LP in the PX — a brand new LP bought in 1963 you know. I got robbed. But now we lived about 60 or 70 miles away — about 120, 130 kilometers away from Nuremberg. So we had to go in on Sunday nights and stay in the dorm all week and then Friday night we'd get on the bus and go back home for the weekend. So I was a senior in high school, it was my last year in high school. So about two months later I walk in the house on a Friday night and something tells me go get that record, go get that record. And I'm going oh man, so sad. I put it on and it's like whoa, hmmm. Suddenly it made all the sense in the world. Obviously I'd been thinking about it subconsciously, unconsciously. Ornette Coleman was the same way. It took me a little longer for Ornette, but the first record I bought from Ornette, I can't remember which one it was but I'd have to look in my library because it's a European pressing of that record. And I put that on and I didn't get back to that for a couple of years. I didn't understand what that was all about. And then one day I put one of Ornette's — it wasn't that record it was another record somewhere, and I put that on and said oh man, whoa, where have I been? Because

like what I did a clinic on today. It's rooted in the melodies and the rhythms, but the rhythms are not supposed to be as hard and fast and they're not supposed to be as repetitive as some of the other kinds of traditional kinds of music are. And when you finally begin to understand the emotional depth as well as the difference in approach for articulation, the difference in approach for harmonic development, the difference of approach in terms of how you block out your phrases, the kind of phrasing that you use is definitely jazz. I mean Ornette Coleman is Charlie Parker. There's no question, Charlie Parker might have played what Ornette plays, if Charlie Parker had continued to move on and I mean — the self destruction that Charlie Parker might have been, might be similar to Trane's self destruction in terms of the increasing harmonic and technical development that both of them obviously were moving along because they were continuing their careers, which goes in two directions simultaneously. It goes towards increasing complexity on the one hand and goes to increasing simplicity simultaneously, almost in a Zen kind of response.

MR: What's the — of the recordings you've done does one stand out as being let's say the least structured and was it a challenge?

RD: No I can't come up with any. No. Because no structure is just as structured as the most complex structured, to me.

MR: Say that again?

RD: Okay. I'll say it again. Having no structure is just as complex as having the greatest amount of structure or the greatest detailed structure. So in other words if somebody writes a chart that is totally through composed, everything has to be read, there's no improvisation, in other words you're in jail interpreting this chart, and on the other hand if you have absolutely nothing to go on, let's just say somebody says we're going to now do "Avarice," that's our theme, now you guys come up with avarice, that's just as complex as going through this totally written out chart. That's my point. Which brings me to the real principle which is good music is good music, lousy music is lousy music, just like Duke Ellington said. To me that's it. So I can't think — I mean most of the projects that I've been involved in I haven't really had too many projects from hell. Somebody asked me last night at dinner, "Tell me about one or two of your projects" — not projects but was it recordings, no gigs — "from hell." And I had to think about it. I could think of some where the working conditions or the living conditions or something were a drag, but generally speaking I can't really think. I can think of a couple of times when the music was really a drag. But I wouldn't call that from hell. It just was a drag because I took this gig and I'm working with this guy, maybe a duo, and he turns out to be a real asshole, a real jerk, and up to that point he'd been a friend and we'd even played

music was being just kind of shunted out by whatever obsession was stuck there. And I got angry because of that, not because of either pissed off at him in friendship or lack of friendship or anything, but just because he was being so disrespectful to the music.

MR: I see. You play on one of my recent favorite CDs and that's with Ray Bryant, a tribute to his piano friends.

RD: Oh you have that?

MR: Man I love that record.

RD: See now that reminds me I need to talk to Ray. I haven't talked to him in probably a year. I mean we haven't worked together in even longer but I really need to call him up and talk to him. Because I mean there's another precious resource, folks. And he's still here. And the people who get to hear him the most are the Japanese because they bring him over for the Golden Fingers concerts every two years.

MR: Right, with Junior Mance and those fellas.

RD: Junior Mance and this year Renee's going again she's going and of course Kenny Barron, who is here.

MR: Kenny Barron is here?

RD: He is here. He's here at the — I haven't seen him but they tell me he's camped out here wandering around so I've got to go hang out with my old drinking buddy.

MR: Well I'll be looking for him actually.

RD: Yeah he's here. He's not doing anything, he's not a clinician and he's not a performer.

MR: When you said, we were talking about people stealing, borrowing, etcetera, other composers, who are the people that you borrowed from on the way up?

RD: Me? Oh I steal from — I don't borrow from anybody, I steal. I do steal. Bartok. I have a tune, I don't know if you're familiar with a record of mine called "The Essence" on DMP with Hank Jones and Billy Higgins. A trio recording. And I wrote a tune, the title tune, "The Essence" is Bartok String Quartet No. 1, it's the principal theme that opens up the quartet [scats] just those four notes. And I took those very same notes, I didn't even transpose it, took the very same notes and wrote this tune "The Essence" behind it. Another time I stole — I have an improvisational theme on a Beethoven String Quartet No. 12 in E flat, the principal theme, I think it's from the second movement of that — he wrote a couple of minor blues actually, wrote them actually for George Coleman but we never recorded them and I recorded one of them on my very first record, so it's called "O J" that's the name of the tune. But my first record was called "Susanita." It's never been a CD. It's still vinyl. That old.

MR: Those things that go around.

RD: Those black things that go around. Well I guess sometimes Fantasy made them red or

MR: Have you ever had an instance where you wrote something and you were thinking this came from somewhere, but it was a while before you placed where that, maybe a little piece of musical inspiration came from?

RD: Oh I'm sure. I mean I can't think of anything right off the bat. I mean as a composer, the whole process of composing is such an incredibly complex, I mean it can become very simplified on one level but the process itself is a pretty complex sort of system because I mean I've composed songs — I mean I have sketch books filled of ideas. And from time to time I'll pull out an idea and say oh — and complete it. Because it's obvious that I was pointing at something, now I hear the whole thing. I just play it and say oh shit! That's the composition.

MR: Do you write at the piano?

RD: Yeah I write at the piano, can write at the bass, sometimes write without anything around. That doesn't happen very often but it has happened a couple of times where all of a sudden something comes to me and I just write it out. But the piano has probably been the resource that I've used the most for composing. One of these days I'm going to get Finale totally under my fingers. That'll become a composing tool for me. Finale, Sibelius or one of those programs. Because they've become highly evolved now and they can be used as a composer's tool rather than just — I know for instance Kenny Werner uses the computer a great deal in composing. For a time Billy Hart and I used to play together in Kenny's trio and during that time he had just discovered how he could compose with a Mac powerbook and Finale, and a keyboard, you know a small synthesizer keyboard, and so he was taking that on the road, you know, writing all sorts of stuff out. Because he can print it right there and try to play it later.

MR: I was looking at your website and —

RD: Uh oh.

MR: I found it interesting that you put Lincoln's Gettysburg Address in there.

RD: That's mine. That's the current offering.

MR: It's really interesting to revisit that speech now. Did you come across it again and then make a connection or is it something you thought of?

RD: No it's something — the Gettysburg Address for me has always been a very important thing, not because it signaled the end of slavery, it didn't, also it signaled the end of separatism, meaning the south asserting its contention that as a Confederate group of — not states, I don't want to call them states — provinces or as a group of individual former states that we have the right to separate ourself out even though we said initially that we were going to part of this United States. Just because we don't like the way you guys are telling us how we're supposed to be running our affairs down here, that included slavery,

that we bear as Americans anyway, trying to figure out our sins that we need to really atone for. Because we haven't atoned — I mean slavery is one of them, various other things that we've done to people, I'm talking about within our country under the guise of either states' rights or the majority rules or whatever. I mean there are several levels of redress that we still need to address as a nation. So to me that has always been the epitome of one of the challenges that still remains in front of us. Lincoln threw down — basically he said look this is what this nation is really all about and so that's what you need to keep in front of you. So no matter what you do and no matter what you start to — when you start to bow down to those who have died, who have laid their lives down for us to get this far, you now, don't forget this is where we're supposed to be going. No matter where you think we've been or where you think we are, that's where we need to go. And that is, ever since I first heard the Gettysburg Address in elementary school it always stuck with me. It's like damn, that is the shit. That's the shit. When I grow up that's what I want to do for a living.

MR: Are you optimistic about the country addressing some of those things that you mentioned in the past?

RD: I'm personally optimistic but I'm secretly cynical — not pessimistic, just cynical — in the sense that for so long de Tocqueville really had it right when he talked about some of the failings of our country, one of them being that we like to put our head in the sand whenever we confront a serious quote problem unquote that we tend to want to run away from it. And we want to renounce things that are American. We're so busy inventing things and constructing things that we just do it and then walk away from it without trying to learn the lessons of it. Whether they succeed or fail, I mean we don't learn either way. I mean it's a particularly American kind of trait. Because we're so busy creating, so busy going on to the next signpost that we never — one thing, we never — we don't like to look behind us to see what's really going on, we don't like to study what we're going at the moment when we do it. I mean these are things that democracy in America, I mean we're talking early nineteenth century here, this guy busted us for that and we haven't really gotten out of any of that. It appears that things like the common good, the public welfare, those concepts are really dead now. It seems also that the protection of the public from the tyrannies of corporate greed, the tyrannies of market manipulation, the tyrannies of the lack of consumer protection and the lack of environmental protection, I mean all of those things and then this has nothing to do with the current political regime. It has all to do with things that have actually gone on since the end of the Johnson administration. I mean I'm really arguing that it started long before that but the point I'm trying to raise here in that this is not something that's either a democratic or a republican kind of

running around here today. But it's just that there has been an undeniable drift to neglecting the real problems that exist in our country at the moment. Racism is an obvious one. Sexism and classism, those are obvious. But things that aren't so obvious, you know, the denial of basic education to everybody, and it doesn't matter whether you've coming from a public school district that has a lot of money or a public school district that doesn't have very much money. I can tell you, and actually I don't have to tell you because you see it too, the kind of students that we're getting from these school systems, it's unbelievable. I mean now I've been gone 25 years. And I finished my first semester, and I'm looking at these papers coming in—

MR: I bet you were shocked.

RD: I am totally shocked. I had no idea that the level of intake — I mean these kids, they don't know anything, I mean just compared to what it was — I mean just a rust belt, blue collar kid coming into a university had better speaking, writing, arithmetic skills, knew more about life, than any of these kids do. And now the best students are kind of similar to some of the best students, but it even becomes skewed with them because you can see certain little things that they don't quite have that the best of the best students that you would see had. And that's like whoa. Wait a minute. What has happened? And I've talked to my mother who retired as a middle school teacher. My mother is a great — I mean I'm not going to get into that too much but hell my mother raised six kids and she went to school and it broke her mother's heart because she had me, she got married and had me at the end of the war instead of finishing her college education, as she was a year away. She went to a small black college, female college, Talladega College in Alabama and met my father and he swept her off her feet and I was born when she was 20 years old and all that kind of stuff. Anyway the point was that she had these six kids and she decided to go back to San Jose State after she'd been gone from college for 25 years raising kids. And they actually looked at her transcript and they said we'll admit you as a second semester junior. And she said, "You will?" They said, "Yeah we'll take your credits" and everything. So she wound up becoming a teacher and doing student teaching in the Monterey Peninsula School District and wound up becoming a teacher and then was there 20 years. She put in 20 years and she gets her retirement. So I mean I just look at that, and I've talked to her and I said what's going on? She says, "Raymond that's the way it is," she says, "it's unfortunate but the standards have just really—"

MR: Does it have anything to do with attention spans do you believe?

RD: I think attention span in part is produced because of the medias. I mean the media and the pace of our lives. I don't think people — I don't think it's genetic or I don't even think it's really culturally induced, I think it's just the pace that everybody has to now live a

reasons that I left the business world, left Stanford, was something that I actually had seen at Allstate while I was there. I was there from ’68 to ’70, for two years, and I left because I could not believe the short attention span that was now developing in American business. When I first got to Allstate in ’68 one of the most important parts of the company in their planning effort was they looked at a five year plan and a ten year plan, and those — the five year plan was in service of the ten year plan so the annual plan was in service of the five year plan, but the five year plan was the most important. The ten year plan was important too, and the one year plan was important to get to the five year plan. But the most important thing was the five year plan. By the time I left Allstate in September of 1970 the quarter was not even as important as each week. See in our monthly — well not monthly — but in our weekly Monday morning meeting, because you have to understand Allstate Insurance Company, there’s a region, this is the region, it’s not a district office or anything, the Menlo Park Regional Office which is Northern California, and Sacramento had the rest of California and Nevada so I had to cover both of those regions. Anyway the point was I’d go to the Menlo Park meeting because that was my home gig. By the time I left our weekly meeting would generally have all the managers trying to make their numbers look the best for the previous week, and the estimates for this coming week were more important than what they were estimating for the month, the quarter, the year, five years, what? What? What is that? Ten years. Who ever heard? What? Ten years exists? And so it’s like I saw that and I said it’s over. American business is finished. There’ll be creative this and that but as far as creating anything, you don’t run a business day to day. The businesses run because you have a vision, still you’re a creative person but you’re a businessperson. And businesspeople don’t just make money, they make the money because they have something that somebody wants, and somebody wants it not because you’re forcing it down their throat, somebody wants it because they can use it. It’s something that’s made well, that somebody wants. And they’re going to go out and get it. Now that upsets traditional marketing — now you want to say traditional, I’d say marketing since the fifties, since the post war. Because post war everybody’s now thinking they’ve been taught all these wonderful concepts about how to manipulate mass markets and how to influence people through media manipulation and this and that. And it works for a time but eventually it runs out of gas for each product. So when you have a product that’s not made well and it’s forced down people’s throats, eventually it peters out. Now a product that’s made well that’s priced well, that stands up, that the company stands behind continues on. I mean it does. There’s no question, even if the product is obsolete, people will still vote to use that product because it works, it’s convenient, it’s priced well. American business is

resisted as long as they could but they're — and it's not even about money either, that's what makes it so sad, because ultimately it's really not about how much we made or how much we didn't make, it's really about how much did we give to our stockholders. And that's such a game that's being played. I mean we see the results of that game, and right now there's a big cover-up going on because it's not about what happened to Enron and those guys it's about what's going on with the rest of all these jacklays, as James Williams says, yeah everybody's trying to figure out a way that they can make sure they can cover up all their tracks. Because everybody's been doing the exact same things as all these other companies. I mean that's what they've been teaching in business school.

MR: Can you tell me, is there a spiritual side to your music? A spiritual element?

RD: I hope so. I hope so. Especially I think it's most evident in "The Excursion." I don't know if you're familiar with that recording at all but "The Excurision" has Lovano and Craig Handy and Mor Thiam, the Senegalese drummer who also was in Don Pullen's "African-Brazilian" connection. Danillo Perez, Marvin "Smitty" Smith. That recording is the most spiritual of all the recordings that I've had. And there is a definitely a spiritual connection, in fact that is the direction that I'd like to actually get deeper into because that's more where I lived than any of the other things that I've done, I mean the other things I'm proud of and I enjoy and all but there is a certain depth to that. I mean that's a kind of a record that you can't play for background music, you can't. You can't even keep it way low. You can't play it for background music, it's just too intense, it's too dense, it's got too much going on, there's obviously something else happening.

MR: Would that be on your short list of things you've played on that you feel the best about?

RD: Yeah I think so. Yeah. Definitely. I'd have to say that probably "Excursion" is one of the things that — it's not that I'm most proud of, because for instance like Hank and Billy, that record, I love the music on it, there are certain engineering values that I'm not too terribly excited about but forget their playing, they're playing is always exemplary but it's just the project and the way it came about and what happened as a result, I mean when I listened to it, it's just a marvelous, Bill Mays, the two recordings with Bill I really enjoy, you know just the two of us playing, and the John Hicks duo one that I love and the one that no one will ever hear because it's tied up in litigation — oh and it's a great record, I produced that too but more importantly it's just the music on there is just so nice. In fact I wish I had it with me right now I'd like to listen to it. But my other records, "Vignettes" for instance I really enjoy, "One Two Three Four," this newest one, it's a little raggedy in spots, places that I would have preferred not to be but hey it's what it is and the guys that are on the record, I mean they — actually, that's the thing about all the recordings that I've been lucky to have under my name, the guys have really given

you know you hire people because of their individual voices and you put them together not because you want them to make a sound that you think they should make but because you hear what they do and you want to put them together with the individual voices so that they will interact and make whatever sound comes out of that. And that's what Miles did. Miles would always do that. Miles was not a person that said I want you to sound like this, I want you to play like this. If anything Miles said, "Uh, you're not playing enough. I didn't hire you to sit here and look good, cute and everything, just play, just be yourself." So that's the kind of ideal that I'm always striving for. So I guess "Excursion" kind of projects would give me the broadest palette at this point. I'd love to have a big band, some big band projects and whatnot. I did my first big band compositions or arrangements rather a couple of years ago for Lafayette College in Easton and that was fun, it was a challenge to actually do them and so I'd love to do that some more. I mean there's billions of things. My Mingus project I want to do, my Gospel project — well not Gospel but it's we talked about spiritual, well American spirituals, I'd like to do, some of them would be black, some of them would be white, some of them would be Native American, some of them might be Asian-American. But tunes considered spirituals or something close to that, where I actually go and re-arrange it and come up with another kind of, actually I got a bunch of ideas for some, I'm a Paul Robeson freak too, I've always loved Paul Robeson. There's a lot of material that he sang and of course his story is completely tragic, certainly it's a political story for the forties and fifties. Definitely. You want to talk about what McCarthy did?

MR: Yeah.

RD: There's a perfect example, a commie under every bush and all that silly — now we have a Bush under every commie.

MR: Well I wish you the best of luck with —

RD: Well thank you, Monk.

MR: I hope you can focus on some of those projects.

RD: Well you know, que sera sera. I'm 56 years old now and I'm as old as the president, the last two presidents, I'm the same age, we were all born the same year. And Dave Holland I, we're about a month and a half apart, and Tom Harrell and I are about four months apart, five months apart. So I see all of us trying to — struggling to get our creative messages out.

MR: It's always some level of struggle.

RD: Yeah. I don't mind the struggle. The struggle is great. I don't mind that it's just that the backdrop in which this struggle continues is one that changes in sometimes unfriendly ways so you always want that backdrop to be at least somewhat — if nothing, at least

MR: Well thanks for your time today.

RD: Thank you.